

Management of International Organizations & NGOs (Spring 2026)

Instructors:

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1. Structure and contents

International organizations (IOs) have been traditionally studied from the perspective of international relations, political science, and international law. This course takes a managerial approach towards key areas of global organizing: the United Nations (UN) system, international financial institutions, global public-private partnerships, international non-governmental organizations (INGOs), and global foundations.

The first part of the course will set the IOs' context of global governance: we will clarify what international organizations are and categorize the main actors in "families." We will then focus attention on the different areas of global organizing (e.g., development, aid and health), and discuss the main issues and institutions involved in each. Subsequently, we will examine how coherence and coordination is achieved within the United Nations system, and how organizational governance is structured. We will conclude with a discussion of managerial issues vis-à-vis INGOs and public-private partnerships.

The second part of the course will provide an overview of the managerial reforms, tools and systems in international organizations. The issues to be considered include financial management, HR management, stakeholder management, profile management and branding, field operations' management, management control, and performance measurement. Lastly, the course will address the growingly important issues of the public profile and accountability of IOs and their executives.

2. Learning outcomes

The course intends to build general and specific knowledge vis-à-vis IOs' organizational structures, and to enable students to develop and apply critical thinking in relation to management tools and reforms. At the end of the course, students will be able to:

- Identify different families of IOs and elaborate on mandate and operations
- Understand the complexity and richness of the UN system, and distinguish roles and governance mechanisms of Funds, Programmes and Specialized Agencies
- Make comparisons between UN system organizations, other IOs and INGOs in terms of operating and governance mechanisms
- Understand the current challenges and open issues of the managerial reforms in IOs and INGOs
- Appreciate the complexity and the need for a tailored approach to management in IOs and INGOs
- Identify the strategic frameworks and distinctive features of management in development cooperation
- Understand how IOs and INGOs operate on the field
- Identify and address the main issues of ethics and accountability from an IOs standpoint

3. Learning approach

This course relies on lectures, class-based case studies, class discussions, collective work on a real-world policy brief, and an optional assignment. **Students are expected to read the case study documents in advance of class, as the class discussion will assume familiarity with the issues raised in the documents.**

4. Materials

All teaching material will be provided to students via blackboard or via the library website, and there is **no need to purchase** any book. In particular, we will use the following:

- (1) Missoni, E., and D. Alesani D. 2023. *Management of International Organizations & NGOs*. Routledge. [Available here](#).
- (2) Federo, R., A. Saz-Carranza, and M. Esteve. 2020. *Management and Governance of Intergovernmental Organizations*. Cambridge University Press. [Available here](#).
- (3) A limited number of chapters or articles; indicated in the table below and on blackboard.

5. Attendance

Attending students are classified as those who submit the collaborative policy brief/presentations, sit for the two partial exams, and attend at least 70% of the lectures. Anyone who does not do so, will be automatically considered non-attending. If you wish to withdraw from the May exam session, you retain your other grades for the June session. After the June session, you will be evaluated as a non-attending student.

6. Assessment

Attending students

The final grade for the course will be based on the following elements:

(A) *One collaborative policy brief and associated presentations, counting for 40% of grade*

Students are expected to produce an in-depth policy brief related to a real-world policy/operational/managerial challenge faced by the UN Development Programme in Cote d'Ivoire. Teams of 7-10 students (depending on number of attending students) will need to develop the following outputs. Students will be able to express 3 equivalent preferences out of a total of 7 proposed projects, but team allocation will ultimately depend on the professors. The deadline for signing up (filling in Google Form to be circulated) should be 11 February at 5pm. Team composition will be announced by 13 February; team allocations will be final.

Output:	Presentation 1	Presentation 2	Presentation 3 and final policy brief
Deadline:	3 March at noon	28 March at noon	7 May at noon
Presentation:	4 March	29 April	13 May
Duration:	20 mins + 10 mins for comments	20 mins + 10 mins for comments	20 mins + 10 mins for comments
Length:	15 slides max	15 slides max	15 slides max and 16-20 pages brief (including tables/figures/boxes, and excluding references)
Description:	Big picture overview of policy problem, and comparative assessment for how different countries, regions and	Analysis of the specific characteristics of Cote d'Ivoire vis-a-vis the policy problem. This should include:	Final presentation and policy brief to UNDP. The main output is a UNDP project proposal. The proposal should be

	international organizations have sought to tackle this problem. Special emphasis should be paid to: - Stakeholders involved - Financing needs - Potential financing sources - Needs for regulatory/legal change - Best practices (or failed practices) from other real-world cases Where feasible, presentations should rely on available data to provide further context or analysis of the policy problem (e.g., tables, maps, visualizations).	- Background of policy problem and policies at stake - Mapping stakeholders - Overview of national policies and plans on this policy problem - Evaluation of actual or potential synergies between UNDP and other IOs - Potentials for donor support Where feasible, presentations should rely on available data to provide further context or analysis of the policy problem (e.g., tables, maps, visualizations).	the result of a thorough organizational analysis, that include what UNDP has done to deal with similar problems around the world and how UNDP operates within Cote d'Ivoire. This should entail: - Clear understanding of UN approach to this problem - Clear understanding of UNDP approach to similar problems - Proposal of concrete project/activities UNDP in Cote d'Ivoire can undertake. This would include (a) analysis of stakeholders; (b) identification of potential partnerships; (c) discussion of funding needs and potential sources; (d) time horizons for project/activity implementation. Where feasible, presentations/briefs should rely on available data to provide further context or analysis (e.g., tables, maps, visualizations).
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(B) Two exams, counting for 30% of grade each

The two exams (midterm and final) will cover the material from the first and second half of the course respectively. To prepare, you need to cover all slides and readings covered in class, and consult your class notes (including discussions of case studies). Each exam will have several multiple-choice questions and one long-answer question and will last 2 hours. The case studies may inform the long-answer question, but their details will not be tested in a multiple-choice format. If you wish to withdraw from the May exam session, you retain your other grades for the June session. After the June session, you will be evaluated as a non-attending student.

(C) An optional short assignment (0-1 points added to your final grade)

Students may elect to write a short assignment related to the fight against climate change to boost their grades. This will take the form of a hypothetical 'explainer' blog post tailored to their substantive interests in terms of organizations and regions. Example topics include: 'How the World Bank is helping Indonesia to tackle climate change,' 'How the European Investment Bank supports climate change adaptation projects in Africa,' ... You are free to choose the exact organization (whether intergovernmental or non-governmental), country/region, and the specific focus (e.g., broad framing on climate change vs narrower frames like coastal adaptation, resilient

infrastructures, etc.). However, your blog **cannot** be on the same organization/topic as your collaborative policy brief. Your blog post should review the evidence and weave it together in a coherent narrative that reflects the organizational identity and mandate. Further guidance will be provided in class I. Short assignments will be graded on a continuum between excellent (adds 1 point to your final mark) and poor (does not alter your final mark). Length should be approximately 700 words (within the 650-750 words range). **Deadline is Sunday 17 May at 11:59pm.**

Non-attending students

For students not regularly attending classes, final grade for this course is based on a final written examination (100%) composed of multiple-choice questions and one long-answer question, based on readings and class slides. The case studies may inform the long-answer question, but their details will not be tested in a multiple-choice format. The exam will last 2 hours.

6. About the instructors

About Alexander Kentikelenis

Alexander Kentikelenis is professor of political economy and sociology at Bocconi. He has published extensively on global governance issues, and has worked as a consultant to various international and public organizations, including the World Health Organization, the European Centre for Disease Control and Prevention, and the German Ministry of International Development. His research has appeared in leading academic journals, and has received wide media coverage in outlets such as the *New York Times*, the *Washington Post*, the BBC, Reuters, and Associated Press. Before joining Bocconi, Alexander held appointments at Oxford, Harvard and Cambridge universities. He holds a PhD from the University of Cambridge.

About Gian Mallarino

Gian Maria Mallarino is a PhD Fellow in Public Policy and Administration at the Department of Social and Political Sciences at Bocconi University. His research focuses on organizational responses to global challenges, with particular emphasis on carbon markets and global health. He currently lectures at Bocconi, teaching undergraduate and graduate courses in international public management and geopolitics. Gian Maria has also served as a consultant for both private and international organizations, including OECD and venture-backed startups in the sustainability industry. He holds a dual bachelor's degree in international business from Università Cattolica and Northeastern University, as well as a dual master's degree in international relations from LUISS and China Foreign Affairs University.

Course Content

#	Date	Topic	Readings
1	4/2	Course presentation & guidance on assessment methods <i>Case study: Tackling corruption at the UN</i>	- Federo, Saz-Carranza and Esteve book: Chapter 3 - Case study: https://hbsp.harvard.edu/tu/517e4252
2	11/2	Overview of the UN system & aid issues	- Missoni and Alesani book: Chapter 1 - OECD. 2008. 'Effective Aid Management': https://www.oecd.org/dac/peer-reviews/40720533.pdf
3	18/2	Managing international development: overview of issues & institutions <i>Case study: Building Strong Partnerships at the Inter-American Development Bank</i>	- Missoni and Alesani book: Chapter 4 - Hale, T., D. Held & K. Young. 2014. <i>Gridlock: Why Global Cooperation Is Failing When We Need It Most</i>. Polity Press. (p. 113-152) - Case study: https://hbsp.harvard.edu/tu/72cf7812
4	25/2	Managing global health: overview of issues & institutions <i>Case study: The WHO's handling of the Ebola crisis</i>	- Clinton, C. & D. Sridhar. 2017. <i>Governing Global Health: Who Runs the World and Why?</i> Oxford: Oxford University Press. [p. 1-21] - Case study: Kamradt-Scott, A. 2016. "WHO's to Blame? the World Health Organization & the 2014 Ebola Outbreak." <i>Third World Quarterly</i> 37(3).
5	4/3	Class presentations, version I	
6	11/3	Coherence, coordination, and governance Mock exam discussion	- Missoni and Alesani book: Chapter 5 - Federo, Saz-Carranza and Esteve book: Chapter 4
7	1/4	Strategic Management in International Organizations - Strategic Management of International Organization - Strategic Planning of projects <i>Case study: The World Bank in 2012 Choosing a Leader</i>	- Missoni and Alesani book: Chapter 10 - Barzelay, M., & Jacobsen, A. S. (2009). Theorizing implementation of public management policy reforms: A case study of strategic planning and programming in the European Commission. <i>Governance</i>, 22(2), 319-334.
8	15/4	Programme implementation and management:	Missoni and Alesani book: Chapters 6 and 11

		- Different paradigms for programme implementation - Result based measurement tools Case Study: The Global Fund	• Lipson, M. (2010). Performance under ambiguity: International organization performance in UN peacekeeping. <i>The Review of International Organizations</i>, 5(3), 249-284. • Achieving Inclusiveness of Country Coordinating Mechanisms, The Global Fund, 2016. Link
9	22/4	Financing of International Organizations and Projects: - Funding patterns for international projects - Fundraising tools for International NGO's Guest speaker: Benedetta Candelise, Programme Office Specialist, Investment Centre at Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations	• Missoni and Alesani book: Chapter 7 • AbouAssi, K. (2013). Hands in the pockets of mercurial donors: NGO response to shifting funding priorities. <i>Nonprofit and Voluntary Sector Quarterly</i>, 42(3), 584-602.
10	29/4	Class presentations, version 2	
11	6/5	Cross Sector Collaborations and Stakeholder Management - Communication Strategies in International Organizations - Stakeholder maps - The pros and cons of cross-sector collaboration Guest speaker: Adriano Ferrara, R&I Project Manager, Ente Nazionale Italiano di Unificazione - International Standards Organization (ISO)	• Missoni and Alesani book: Chapter 16 • Utting, P., & Zammit, A. (2009). United Nations-business partnerships: Good intentions and contradictory agendas. <i>Journal of Business Ethics</i>, 90(1), 39-56. • <u>Case Study</u>: Missoni and Alesani book: Chapter 16.7
12	13/5	Class presentations to UNDP, final	